



A-Worthy Education · a-worthy.com

O-Level English: A Framework for Every Question

One named method for each question type on the O-Level English papers, with its steps, a worked example and the errors it prevents.

LEVEL Secondary 1 to 4 · GCE O-Level English Language (Syllabus 1184)



How to use this guide

Each section covers one part of the English papers. It states what the framework is for, lists its steps, works an example and names the errors it prevents. Every framework is the **Hit** step of the SHARP routine we use in class:

S See	H Hit	A Apply	R Refine	P Practise
Name the question type before you write.	Pick the framework for that type from this guide.	Write the answer, one step at a time.	Check the answer against the error list.	Redo the question from memory a few days later.

Work on one section at a time, with a past-paper question of that type, and copy the steps into the margin until you can recall them unaided. After marking, find each lost mark on the section's error list: it tells you which step you skipped. Before a test, revise from the one-page summary table at the end.

1 Editing: STAMP CARD

Paper 1 · Section A · 10 marks · a passage of up to 250 words

The editing passage contains grammatical errors. SEAB does not test punctuation or spelling in this section. STAMP CARD gives you nine categories to check on every numbered line, so you search for each error instead of waiting for it to stand out.

Steps

1. Sweep the three categories that appear in almost every passage first: **T** (tense), **S** (subject-verb agreement) and **A**² (adjective or adverb).
2. Work the remaining letters in order on each line: **A**¹, **M**, **P**, **C**, **R**, **D**.
3. Stop on a line as soon as you find its error, write the correction and move on.
4. Re-read the passage once more for tense only, to catch a verb that shifts silently.
5. Leave a line unchanged if no category flags an error. Some lines are correct.

Worked example: one fix for each letter

	Category and quick check	Error in the line, then the fix
S	Subject-verb agreement. Does the verb agree with its true subject in number?	The average age of caregivers are about 62. Fix: is . Cover "of caregivers": the subject, "the average age", is singular.
T	Tense. Is the tense right for the time markers?	I have seen that film last night. Fix: saw . "Last night" fixes the event in the past.
A ¹	Articles. Is it a, an or the, judged by sound, not spelling?	He is a honest student. Fix: an . "Honest" begins with a vowel sound.
M	Match pronouns. Does the pronoun match its antecedent in number, gender and form?	The teacher gave the book to John and I. Fix: me . After "to", use the object form.
P	Prepositions. Is the preposition right? Watch fixed phrases.	She is interested on the new project. Fix: in . The fixed phrase is "interested in".

	Category and quick check	Error in the line, then the fix
C	Connectors. Is the linking word logically right?	Although he was tired, but he kept working. Fix: delete but . "Although" already signals the contrast.
A ²	Adjective or adverb. Does the word describe a noun (adjective) or a verb (adverb)?	She speaks fluent during the presentation. Fix: fluently . It modifies the verb "speaks".
R	Right number. Singular or plural? Does the quantifier match?	Less students passed the exam this year. Fix: Fewer . "Students" is a countable plural.
D	Degree of comparison. Is the comparative or superlative right, and not doubled?	She is more smarter than her brother. Fix: smarter . Never add "more" to a comparative that already ends in "er".

Errors this framework prevents

- Matching the verb to the nearest noun instead of the true subject.
- Missing a tense shift in the middle of a paragraph.
- Changing spelling or punctuation, which this section does not test.
- Changing a correct line to force an error into it.

2 Situational Writing: PAC and the Four-Move Expansion

Paper 1 · Section B · 30 marks (Task Fulfilment 10, Language 20) · 250 to 350 words, aim for 300 to 320 · about 30 to 35 minutes

You write a text for a given situation and visual text, such as an email, a letter, a report or a speech. Task Fulfilment checks three things: every point addressed and developed; purpose, audience and context made clear; the given information used. The PAC analysis fixes the frame and the four-move expansion develops each point.

Steps

1. **Read and analyse.** Underline the text type, the role you write as, the audience and each content point. Split any double-barrelled point, such as "suggest one activity and explain why it would appeal", into two, then number every point.
2. **Write the PAC** in three short lines: **Purpose** (why am I writing?), **Audience** (who reads this?), **Context** (what has happened, and what is my standing?). Then write the register in one word: formal, semi-formal or informal.
3. **Arrange the plan.** Number each usable detail in the visual text by the point it serves and strike out the rest. Plan five paragraphs: opening, one per content point, closing.
4. **Write.** Put the format elements in first, state your purpose in the first sentence of the body, and build each point paragraph with the four-move expansion below.
5. **Check tone, then proofread.** Keep one register from first line to last. Read from the last sentence backwards for agreement, tense, punctuation and spelling, and cross off every numbered point.

Move	Question it answers (one or two sentences each; about 60 to 80 words a paragraph)
State	What is the point, in one clear sentence?
Specify	What detail from the visual text, or what plausible particular, makes it concrete: a time, a number, a place, a name, a condition?
Show	What follows from it: the consequence, the cause or the difficulty?
Sell	Why should this reader care? What is gained, avoided or protected, in the reader's terms?

PEEL (Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link) is an alternative way to develop a point to the same depth.

Format checklists: planning aids only

Text type	Acronym	What it reminds you to include
Formal letter	CHOPE IT	Correct addresses · Header · Opening · Points · Ending · Ink the right sign-off · Tone
Informal letter	SHIOK	Start warmly · Heart · Include all points · Offer support · Keep it warm
Email	STAMP (email format checklist, not STAMP CARD)	Subject line · To/From/Date · Address the reader · Main body · Polite close

Text type	Acronym	What it reminds you to include
Report	TIKAM	Title block · Introduction · Key findings · Actions · Make a conclusion
Speech	KENA	Kick off with a hook · Engage the audience · Narrate the points · Ask them to act
Proposal	BOLEH	Big idea · Outline the plan · List the benefits · Expect concerns · Hope for approval
Article	CLICK	Catchy headline · Lead with a hook · Illustrate with examples · Connect the points · Kick-end

Never write an acronym into your answer script. Examiners do not recognise these terms and award no mark for them; they belong in your planning margin. The syllabus names the email, letter, report and speech; the proposal and the article are school conventions that are often tested.

WORKED EXAMPLE

One content point, developed in four moves: formal, to a principal

State The congestion in the canteen during the first break has become a serious difficulty for the lower secondary levels.

Specify With all six levels released at 9.45 a.m., the queues regularly extend past the notice board, and Secondary One students frequently reach the front with fewer than five minutes remaining.

Show Many of them therefore return to class without eating, and several have reported feeling unwell during the fourth period.

Sell Staggering the break would remove this problem at no cost to the school and would reduce the disruption that late arrivals currently cause to lessons.

Errors this framework prevents

- Answering only half of a double-barrelled point: “most” points instead of “all” caps Task Fulfilment at Band 3.
- Stopping at State and Specify, so the point is mentioned but not developed.
- Copying details from the visual text word for word instead of turning them into reasons, consequences or benefits.
- Register drift: a formal opening that slides into informality, or “Yours faithfully” after a named salutation.
- An acronym such as CHOPE IT written into the answer script.

3 Continuous Writing: Story Spine and P-E-E-L

Paper 1 · Section C · 30 marks (Content 10, Language 20) · one of four topics · 350 to 500 words

A narrative needs a story with a structure; an expository or argumentative essay needs paragraphs that reason. The story spine plans the first; P-E-E-L builds each body paragraph of the second.

Steps

1. Choose the topic in under three minutes. Cross out any topic for which you cannot think of two concrete examples, then pick one where you can already see the ending.
2. Read the command: is the topic narrative, expository or argumentative?
3. Narrative: plan the **story spine** in five minutes. **Character**: who is the protagonist, and what do they want? **Arc**: what tension drives the story? **Plot**: setup, complication, resolution. **Setting**: where and when, and how it shapes the mood.
4. Expository or argumentative: build each body paragraph in **P-E-E-L**. **Point**: a topic sentence that answers the question. **Evidence**: a specific example, not a generalisation. **Explanation**: two or three sentences on how the evidence supports the point. **Link**: connect back to your thesis and lead into the next paragraph.
5. Place your strongest description at three moments: the opening line, the climax and the closing image. Then replace weak verbs with precise ones.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Topic (illustrative): “Write about a time when you had to keep a promise.”

Character Aaron, a Secondary 3 student, wants to win the class art prize.

Arc He has promised to coach his younger sister for her spelling test on the evening the artwork is due.

Plot Setup: the promise at breakfast. Complication: the art deadline moves forward a day. Resolution: he keeps the promise, submits a smaller piece and decides what the prize is worth to him.

Setting A small flat on one wet evening, which puts both tasks on the same kitchen table.

Show, don't tell. Instead of “I was nervous”, write “My fingers drummed against the desk, leaving damp half-moons on the wood.”

Errors this framework prevents

- A string of events with no turning point, or an ending squeezed into the last two lines.
- Body paragraphs that make a point and give an example but never explain it.
- Vague evidence such as “many people say”.
- A narrative that switches between past and present tense.

4 Comprehension: SWIFT, then FLIP or EIL

Paper 2 · Section B (Text 3, narrative, 20 marks) · Section C (Text 4, non-narrative, 25 marks including the summary)

SWIFT is a five-second test that decides whether the answer is already in the passage (Category A) or has to be inferred (Category B). The category then fixes the method.

SWIFT signals: Suggest (“What does this suggest...”) · Why (“Why do you think...”) · Impression (“What impression...”, “What sort of person...”) · Feeling (“state of mind”, “reaction”, “How did X feel...”) · Tone (“tone”, “attitude”).

Steps

1. Read the questions before the passage. Circle the command words and note the paragraph each question names.
2. Run SWIFT. A signal means Category B; no signal means Category A. A “why” question whose answer the passage states, such as “In your own words, explain why the town changed”, stays in Category A.
3. Category A, use **FLIP**: Find the relevant lines in the named paragraph; Lift the exact words you need; Interpret what they mean in plain English; Paraphrase only if the question says “in your own words”.
4. Category B, use **EIL**: Evidence, the exact word, phrase or action; Implication, what it suggests, in your own words; Link, tied back to exactly what the question asked.
5. Check the mark allocation: one point per mark, no more.

WORKED EXAMPLE

Sorting: “Give one detail that shows the writer was nervous” is Category A: you can underline the answer. “What does ‘she pressed her lips together’ suggest about her mood?” is Category B: “suggest” means you must work the meaning out.

Question: Explain what the writer suggests about the town through the phrase “the streets were scrubbed clean of life” (line 12). [2]

Weak answer: “The town was very quiet and there was no one around.” It describes the scene, quotes nothing and misses the sinister edge of “scrubbed clean”.

E The phrase “scrubbed clean of life”

I suggests the town has been deliberately emptied,

L implying an unsettling, almost sinister absence of people rather than an ordinary quiet.

Vocabulary in context: put your answer into the sentence in place of the word. In “the atmosphere was charged with tension”, “charged” means “filled”, not “accused”.

Errors this framework prevents

- A literal answer to an inference question: describing instead of interpreting.
- Evidence with no interpretation, or an interpretation with no evidence.
- Lifting whole sentences when the question asks for your own words.
- One point for a two-mark question, or a dictionary meaning that does not fit the sentence.

5 Summary: CAPS

Paper 2 · Section C · about 80 words, excluding the introductory words provided

The summary is marked for its content points and for style: SEAB's style band rewards the use of your own words and structures. CAPS gives you four moves for rewriting each point without dropping content.

Steps

1. First pass: underline every point that answers the question. Ignore the word count for now.
2. Number and sort the points. Decide whether the task has one theme (single-part) or two sides (two-part).
3. Rewrite each point with CAPS: **C**ombine and condense, **A**lter word class, **r**e**P**urpose structure, **S**wap words.
4. Single-part: one theme in about 80 words. Two-part: about 40 words for each side, joined by one transition sentence.
5. Check the word count, then check that no point was lost in the rewriting.

WORKED EXAMPLE

CAPS move	Before	After
Combine and condense: fuse sentences, or use a category term for a list.	Renewable energy reduces carbon emissions. It also lowers electricity costs.	Renewable energy reduces carbon emissions and lowers electricity costs.
Alter word class: turn a noun into a verb and rebuild.	The destruction of the forest was rapid.	The forest was destroyed rapidly.
rePurpose structure: reorder clauses or switch voice.	The cat chased the mouse.	The mouse was chased by the cat.
Swap words: synonyms in the right register; never technical terms or names.	The policy will help reduce pollution.	The policy will assist in curbing pollution.

Transitions for a two-part summary. Causes and consequences: "As a result," or "Consequently,". Benefits and drawbacks: "However," or "Despite these advantages,". Past and present: "Today, however," or "Since then,". Problems and solutions: "To address these issues," or "In response,".

Errors this framework prevents

- Lifting the writer's phrases, which the style band does not reward.
- Swapping a technical term or a proper noun for a synonym.
- Spending words on examples and minor details while main points are missing.
- Running well over 80 words, or a two-part summary with no transition.

Summary: every framework on one page

Paper and question	Framework	Steps
Paper 1 · Editing	STAMP CARD	Sweep T, S and A ² first; then A ¹ , M, P, C, R, D on every line; one correction per line; re-read for tense; leave correct lines alone.
Paper 1 · Situational writing	PAC and the four-move expansion	Read and analyse (split double-barrelled points). PAC: Purpose, Audience, Context; register in one word. Plan five paragraphs. Each point: State, Specify, Show, Sell. Check tone, proofread. Format acronyms stay in the margin.
Paper 1 · Narrative	Story spine	Character, Arc, Plot (setup, complication, resolution), Setting. Strongest description at the opening, the climax and the close.
Paper 1 · Expository and argumentative	P-E-E-L	Point, Evidence, Explanation, Link in every body paragraph.
Paper 2 · Comprehension	SWIFT, then FLIP or EIL	SWIFT signals: Suggest, Why, Impression, Feeling, Tone. Category A (no signal): Find, Lift, Interpret, Paraphrase if asked. Category B (signal): Evidence, Implication, Link. One point per mark.
Paper 2 · Summary	CAPS	Underline and sort the points. Combine, Alter word class, rePurpose structure, Swap words. About 80 words; a transition sentence if two-part.

Free report on a recent test or exam: a-worthy.com/contact/ · WhatsApp +65 8991 3181